

FOREWORD

A little before Christmas 1611, a young girl led her blind, elderly grandmother to a mill-owner's house to request payment for work recently done. Not wanting to pay up, the mill-owner yelled at the women, "Get out of my ground, whores and witches, I will burn the one of you, and hang the other."

The elder woman wanted revenge, and she knew how to get it. "The speediest way," she later said, "to take a man's life by witchcraft is to make a picture of clay, like unto the shape of the person whom they mean to kill," prick it with a thorn or pin to cause pain, burn the clay figure, and "thereupon by that means, the body shall die."

This woman who believed herself and was believed by others to be a witch was Elizabeth Southern, also known as Old Demdike. She was 80 years old and one of 20 people arrested in the English Pendle Witch Trials of 1612. She died awaiting trial, but 10 accused with her were hanged for having bewitched others to death "by devilish practice and hellish means," including Elizabeth's granddaughter, Alison.

Fear of witches and harmful magic, objects as intermediaries for the working of magic, and the use of magic by the powerless to gain agency are all recurring themes in this wonderful, global study of magical beliefs and practices. We move through time and space from ancient Mesopotamia and Egypt, through Roman *præcantrices* (female seers), Zoroastrian magic, medieval Japanese alchemy, and Scandinavian wand-carriers, through to Voudon (Voodoo), Ouija boards, Father Christmas, Wicca, and much else besides.

Such an all-encompassing survey teaches us that while the forms of magic—the spells, rituals, and powers—have varied, those turning to magic have fundamentally had similar concerns. They have wanted power over that which was naturally beyond their control: they have wanted to challenge the inexplicable and get a handle on the ambiguous and uncomfortable. The Inuit people of Greenland, we learn, for example, came to believe in spirit powers who controlled the bitter, frozen wastelands in which they lived. Magic promises to help with daily tasks that easily go wrong, control weather that destroys crops, and bring solace to the infertile or the sick. This means that there has always been a role for those who believe

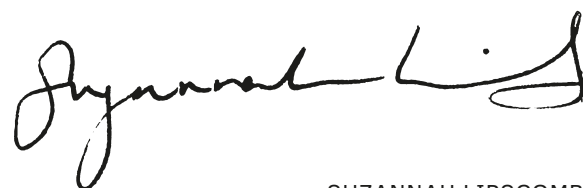
they can mediate with spirits, ward off evil, and stand on the threshold between the seen world of humans and the unseen realms of the spiritual. This is why magic has preoccupied people for centuries, and continues to do so.

I am especially struck by the vast number of ways in which humans have always tried to grapple with something over which we have zero control: that we live in linear time and do not know the future. It's not just tea leaves and palmistry: it's libanomancy (divination by looking at the patterns of a flame from a lamp), ornithomancy (observing the flight of birds), and even, my favorite, chremetismomancy (interpreting horses' neighs).

Often these forms of divination, like most magic, have been forbidden. Although the line between magic and miracle is a fine one, and where it falls largely depends on the beholder, magic has often been considered transgressive. And although magic has frequently been incorporated into dominant religions, it has, in turn, subverted orthodoxies and challenged established power structures.

Nowhere is this clearer than in beliefs about witchcraft. Those accusing others of witchcraft were themselves seeking supernatural explanations for misfortune. The great European witch craze of the 16th and 17th centuries, in which nearly 50,000 people were executed, rested also on the ideas that evil power came from the devil and—as women were thought to be weaker and more susceptible to diabolic temptation—that most witches were female, using their magical powers to manipulate men.

Magic is a topic around which misinformation swirls, like mists around a witch's cauldron. This spellbinding book will dispel the fog, lift the enchantment, and vividly illuminate this perennially fascinating subject.



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